became irrational and extreme. His public outbursts also began damaging the reputation of the Tata Group. In February 1992, Mody declared that ‘he would continue to head Tata Iron and Steel for another 10 to 12 years’. ‘Retirement had never entered his mind,’ wrote *Asiaweek*.

Besides, Mody’s string of actions blemishing the Tatas’ reputation following the fallout of the re-designation orders in TISCO in 1991 and the events the unfolded in its aftermath had fouled the atmosphere in the company and bedevilled its functioning. The die was cast.

Within a week of JRD meeting the Prime Minister and the finance minister, a TISCO board meeting was fixed for 28 May 1992. During the meeting, it was decided that Mody would meet informally with the directors and arrive at a decision on his stepping down as the MD. ‘Finding himself totally isolated’, Mody threw in the towel.

A formal meeting was thereafter called, and it gave its imprimatur to all the decisions taken at the informal meeting. Mody’s bête noire, J.J. Irani, was appointed as his successor. Though Mody would have turned seventy-five on 17 January, it was decided that he could continue as the executive chairman until June of the following year when his contract expired.

To uphold the dignity of the outgoing chief managing director and not make it appear that he was being stripped of all his executive powers, the board approved the formation of a four-member executive committee and vested it with decision-making powers. Though the committee was to be headed by Mody, it was clear that its three members, Ratan, Shahrokh Sabavala and J.J. Irani, would, in effect, curtail the chair’s authority and power.

Mody had underestimated Ratan’s resolve to be unwavering when principles were at stake. This, combined with Mody’s delusion that TISCO could not run without him at the helm, proved to be his undoing.

Swansong

When Mody was replaced as the MD, he became openly antagonistic towards his successor, Irani, and towards Ratan. He frequently used the media, both print and electronic, to stage his attacks. With his unrelenting criticism, the Tatas’ public image continued to suffer. Mody’s unrestrained pronouncements and misinterpretation of facts created panic among the company’s shareholders as well.